him, but it was credit to Stuart and the rest of us too. We never once thought to ourselves: he's not good enough to be playing for Ridgeway.

Stuart had to have everything done properly. We always had a decent field on which to play our home games, like the one at Ainslie Wood Sports Ground, which was just a short walk from home. We trained twice a week. Stuart lived nearby, in Larkswood Road, and there was a park there, with decent facilities, that we used to use. One way or another, Stuart would make sure we had what we needed. When we had important games, like Cup finals, he'd insist on us eight and nine-year-olds wearing a collar and tie. One important rule was that if you didn't turn up for training in the week, then you didn't play at the weekend; it was as simple as that. It was a good habit to learn: I always made sure I was there and that I was there on time. I loved the training anyway. Lived for it. But it was also another reason we had such a good team: Ridgeway Rovers always went about things the right way.

With so many boys' sides, you notice the most talented players. They make a big fuss of the individuals in the team. That wasn't allowed with Ridgeway: any showing off and you'd be brought back down. It was all about the team. In no time, we were starting to win games ten-and eleven-nil and people could see there was something special about us. Professional clubs started scouting our players, and I think west Ham asked about me when I was eleven. But Stuart, Steve and my dad had decided that there should be no need for any of us to be involved with clubs until we were older. If you were training with a professional club, the rule was you couldn't be training with a Sunday League team at the same time. I knew I didn't want that, I wasn't ready for it. We all stuck with Ridgeway. I think, in the long run, those rules were why so many of us went on to make a success of ourselves. We learned about commitment and dedication right from the start.

I had to learn about not playing soccer too. Because I was smaller than most, I used to get my share of knocks. Dad had drummed into me that, most of the time, the best thing to do was just get up and get on with it, like I'd had to with his mates over at Wadham Lodge. He taught me a lot about avoiding injury as well. As a winger—and because people were starting to hear about me a bit—I often had a defender trying to give me a kick. Dad worked with me on keeping the ball moving, releasing it quickly once it was under control. That still helps me keep out of scrapes as a professional player. And it's the best way to play. When I was about ten, I did have one layoff through injury: the kind that happens to lots of boys. Running and jumping all the time, especially on hard fields, ends up jarring knees, shins and ankles. With me, it was my heels: pins and needles at first and then, later, aching during and after